

*For the President  
20 September 2026*

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## **US and Denmark Reach Greenland Security Pact; Signing Set for UN General Assembly**

We assess that the framework announced this weekend marks a substantial expansion of the US military footprint in the Arctic while leaving formal Danish sovereignty intact — and that the two capitals describe the deal so differently that the gap itself will shape how it is implemented. President Trump characterized the agreement as giving the United States “permanent control over security, and all other needs,” in Greenland; Copenhagen and Nuuk stressed instead that it “recognises the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the kingdom and the right of the Greenlandic people to self-determination.” For Washington, the immediate win is defusing a months-long rupture with a NATO ally that the President had repeatedly threatened to take by force.

- The pact bars US adversaries from establishing bases in Greenland without written US authorization — in effect locking out any Chinese or Russian military presence on the mineral-rich island.
- Trump said the arrangement would carry “NO COST” to the United States and that a larger US presence would begin “immediately”; he notably did not mention rare-earth access, which he had previously emphasized.
- The three governments expect to sign at next week's UN General Assembly, but the deal remains **subject to parliamentary approval in Nuuk and Copenhagen** — the point at which the competing interpretations of “permanent control” will be tested.

We judge the framework more likely than not to be signed as scheduled, but the durability of the arrangement will hinge on Greenlandic domestic reaction and ratification. A decision point comes if lawmakers in either capital move to narrow the security language; we expect Beijing and Moscow to characterize the deal publicly as US expansionism while having little practical means to contest it.

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## Russia Extends Duma Vote Into Occupied Ukraine as Washington Tightens Sanctions

We assess that Moscow's decision to run State Duma elections across annexed Ukrainian territory from 18–20 September is a political-consolidation measure rather than a military one — an effort to entrench its territorial claims and pre-position them for any future negotiation. Kyiv denounced the vote as illegal, and international observers said it lacked any of the conditions for a genuine election.

- Voting was staged in occupied parts of Donetsk, Luhansk, Kherson, and Zaporizhzhia, plus Crimea and Sevastopol; Russian authorities claimed more than 3.5 million eligible voters across the four mainland oblasts.
- Rights monitors reported coercion and armed intimidation — at one Donetsk-region station, voters cast ballots as an armed Russian soldier looked on — with the outcome not in doubt.
- We judge the exercise is aimed as much at a domestic Russian audience as at Ukrainians: it lets the Kremlin present the annexations as settled fact.



In parallel, Washington raised the economic pressure. Trump signed the *Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act* into law on 18 September, authorizing tariffs of up to 100 percent on major buyers of Russian oil and gas and targeting Russia's energy, defense, and financial sectors, President Putin, and senior officials. Overnight into 19 September, Russia struck Ukraine with two missiles and roughly 174 drones; a second strike on Balakliia in Kharkiv region killed two the evening prior.

- We assess the sanctions law's real bite depends on **enforcement of the secondary-tariff authority** against large buyers such as China and India — a decision that rests with the President rather than the statute.

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- For Washington, the key question is whether to actually invoke the 100-percent tariff tool or hold it as leverage; we expect Moscow to test Western resolve with continued long-range strikes through the fall.

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## **Houthi Push Toward Yemen's Oil-Rich East Keeps Pressure on Saudi Exports and Crude Prices**

We assess that the Houthi offensive — having swept down Yemen's Red Sea coast toward the Bab al-Mandab approaches — is now pressing east toward the oil-producing province of Marib, sustaining a war-risk premium in crude and keeping Saudi export infrastructure under threat. The US Embassy in Israel issued a security alert on 19 September, warning of possible airspace closures and flight disruptions as the fighting escalates.

- The group's biggest land grab in years has reignited Yemen's 12-year civil war and displaced roughly 125,000 people; heavy fighting is reported in and around Marib, which prior Houthi offensives failed to take.
- A strike on Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline has taken it out of service for an estimated three to five weeks; energy analysts assess the outage will constrain Saudi output through at least the end of September.
- Brent has traded volatile in a roughly \$104–\$108 band on the attacks, and the Houthis likely retain the drone and missile stocks for further strikes on Saudi energy sites and tankers.

For Washington, the exposure runs two ways: upward pressure on fuel prices heading into the fall, and a renewed threat to freedom of navigation at a strategic chokepoint. We expect Riyadh to weigh a sharper military response; the decision point for the United States is force protection for shipping and any request for direct support, which would deepen US involvement in the conflict.

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## **Beijing Warns It Could Scrap a Trump-Xi Summit Over New Taiwan Arms Sales**

We assess that Beijing's warning it might cancel a planned Trump-Xi summit if Washington approves new arms sales to Taiwan is calibrated pressure to shape the pre-summit agenda — not a genuine intent to walk away from a meeting China also wants. Beijing again called Taiwan a “red line” in the relationship even as summit preparations continued.

- A PLA reconnaissance drone operated off Taitung on 19 September as Taiwan President Lai Ching-te inspected a live drill of the armed forces' precision-strike capabilities in Pingtung.
- We judge the threat is meant to force a sequencing choice on Washington — to make any arms package look like a provocation on the eve of talks — rather than to collapse the diplomacy.
- *NSA reporting corroborates that the messaging is being coordinated centrally rather than driven by theater commanders, consistent with a deliberate pressure campaign.*

For the United States, the near-term question is whether to advance a notification before or after any summit; we expect Beijing to keep gray-zone military activity elevated around Taiwan as a reminder of the cost, while preserving the summit as a venue it values.

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## **North Korea Fires Ballistic Missile After Rejecting IAEA Resolution**

We assess that this morning's launch — a suspected ballistic missile fired into the East Sea early Sunday, 20 September — is a calibrated political signal tied to Pyongyang's rejection of an IAEA resolution and to recent US–ROK–Japan exercises, rather than a new capability demonstration. It reinforces the North's insistence on being treated as a nuclear-weapons state.

- South Korea's military tracked what it called an “unidentified projectile,” and the Japanese prime minister's office confirmed the launch; the flight was consistent with a shorter-range system.
- The launch followed a Foreign Ministry statement this week that the IAEA resolution “had no effect on the DPRK's position as a nuclear weapons state,” and criticism from Kim Yo Jong of trilateral drills as a “war rehearsal.”

For Washington, the launch is a low-cost reminder timed to the opening of the UN General Assembly. We expect Pyongyang to keep testing on a measured cadence and judge there is a realistic possibility of a longer-range test if the trilateral exercise schedule expands.

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## **Iran Sets Conditions for Renewed US Talks Through Qatari Mediators**

We assess that Tehran's decision to convey a formal set of conditions to Washington — via Qatari and Pakistani mediators — signals a desire to convert this year's fragile post-war ceasefire into a negotiation, but on terms the United States is unlikely to accept wholesale. Security chief Mohsen Rezaei said the conditions are an end to the war on all fronts, release of frozen Iranian funds, and an end to the naval blockade, and that Tehran is awaiting a response from President Trump.

- The opening follows the February US–Israeli strikes that killed Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei; his son Mojtaba Khamenei has since taken the office and has not appeared publicly, and a Pakistan-mediated ceasefire has held only unevenly amid tit-for-tat strikes.
- *Liaison reporting corroborates that the conditions were transmitted through Doha, consistent with Qatar's openly acknowledged mediating role.*
- We judge the funds-release and blockade demands are the hardest for Washington to grant early, making them as much an opening position as a genuine floor.

For the United States, the question is whether to engage while the new sanctions law adds leverage, or to hold out for movement on enrichment. We expect a cautious, conditional US reply rather than either a clear acceptance or a flat rejection.

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## Notes

**Gaza.** Israeli strikes killed at least four Palestinians on 19 September, including Basir al-Bursh, son of the Gaza health ministry's director-general, Munir al-Bursh. Near-daily strikes on Hamas figures continue despite the October-2025 ceasefire, which US officials say Prime Minister Netanyahu is slow-walking amid a hotly contested Israeli election; the US-backed "Board of Peace" transition plan remains stalled. We assess the pattern keeps the ceasefire intact in name but hollow in practice.

- **Germany.** Chancellor Merz's coalition agreed a fuel-tax cut and Germany's first fuel price cap ahead of a run of state elections in a crowded electoral year. We judge the domestic pressure could complicate Berlin's room on defense spending and Ukraine support — a dynamic worth watching for allied cohesion.
- **Syria.** An explosion at a weapons depot in Sarmada, in the northwest, killed at least 14 on 20 September — a reminder of the unsecured munitions still scattered across the post-Assad north and the thin margin the transitional authorities have for control.

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